

Manifesto of Imperial Selfhood: The Age of Personal Imperialism and Its Spiritual Existence

An Exploratory Essay on Personal Imperialism and Spiritual Sovereignty (Revised and Expanded Edition)

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Prepared for open-access distribution via Zenodo, Academia.edu, and ResearchGate. This revised edition was prepared with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic); see the Declaration on the Use of Artificial Intelligence at the end of this document.

August 2026

Abstract

This essay develops personal imperialism as a heuristic framework for thinking about the integration of selfhood under conditions of late-modern fragmentation. The term does not denote empire as a form of state, still less any claim to dominion over other persons; it names a strictly reflexive project — the individual's cultivation of an internally sovereign order — assembled from three philosophically heterogeneous sources. From Immanuel Kant's Kingdom of Ends, the essay draws a legislative register: the self as simultaneously the author and the subject of its own governing law. From Friedrich Nietzsche's will to power, read cautiously and with attention to the contested editorial status of that phrase within his corpus, it draws an evaluative register: the ceaseless re-creation of the values that legislation alone cannot supply. From Ernst Jünger's *Gestalt of the Worker*, it draws a mobilizational register: the total absorption of the self's capacities into lived, actual form. Rather than presenting these three registers as smoothly compatible layers, the essay argues that their real philosophical tensions — Kantian universalism against Nietzschean perspectivism, legislated stability against perpetual revaluation — are constitutive of the concept rather than defects to be resolved away. It closes by confronting the central risk of its own vocabulary: that a rhetoric of empire, however reflexively bounded, imports the historical freight of conquest and domination. The essay is offered as an exploratory and programmatic contribution, not a completed doctrine.

Keywords: personal imperialism; self-sovereignty; autonomy; Kant; Kingdom of Ends; Nietzsche; will to power; Jünger; total mobilization; technologies of the self

1. Introduction

Contemporary discussions of subjectivity converge, from many directions, on a diagnosis of fragmentation: the self as a bundle of provisional identifications, distributed across roles and platforms, without a stable center that could be called sovereign over the rest. This essay does not attempt to adjudicate that diagnosis; it takes it as the background condition against which a specific conceptual proposal — personal imperialism — is worth articulating.

The term requires an immediate qualification, because it is easy to misread. "Imperialism" here does not denote empire as a form of state, and the essay makes no claim about how one person should relate to another. What it names is narrower and stranger: a will toward integration

operating as an inner principle of governance, directed exclusively at the plurality of drives, roles, and evaluative commitments that make up a single life. Why retain a word this loaded, when gentler alternatives — autonomy, self-governance, integrity — are available and carry none of empire's historical freight? Because those gentler words already name something else: a disposition to follow self-given rules, or a state of being undivided. Personal imperialism is meant to name something more demanding — the active, ongoing work of incorporating otherwise-competing internal factions under a single order, in something like the way an empire, unlike a small and homogeneous republic, must continually integrate what it did not originally contain. It is this connotation of active incorporation, redirected entirely inward and stripped of any claim on other persons, that the essay wants to put to work. Whether this redirection can be accomplished cleanly, or whether the vocabulary of empire carries its violence with it regardless, is a live question the essay does not resolve in advance; it is taken up directly in Section 5, and the reader is entitled to treat everything before that section as provisional pending that reckoning.

With that qualification in place, the essay proceeds in four further steps. Section 2 reconstructs the three philosophical resources from which personal imperialism is assembled, treating each with enough textual and historical specificity to show what is gained, and what is distorted, by importing it into a theory of the self. Section 3 proposes a tripartite structure — legislative, evaluative, and mobilizational — and argues that the real tensions between the three sources are not an embarrassment to be smoothed over but the structure's operative content. Section 4 situates the proposal against the nearest existing discourses, chiefly Foucault's technologies of the self and the Stoic tradition of self-governance. Section 5 confronts the proposal's most serious objections directly, including the terminological risk flagged above. Section 6 concludes with an appropriately modest statement of what has, and has not, been established.

2. Theoretical Foundations

2.1 Kant: The Kingdom of Ends as Inner Legislation

Kant introduces the Kingdom of Ends (Reich der Zwecke) in the Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals as the third formulation of the categorical imperative, following the Formula of Universal Law and the Formula of Humanity (Kant [1785] 2012). A rational being, on Kant's argument, must act only on maxims that could hold as universal law, and must never treat humanity, in itself or in another, merely as a means. The Kingdom of Ends draws these two demands together: a possible systematic union of rational beings under common law, in which every member is simultaneously legislating — giving the law — and subject to it. What makes the community a kingdom of ends, rather than a kingdom of mere obedience, is precisely this double status: no member simply receives law from an external sovereign. Autonomy, for Kant, is this self-legislating structure, and it is what heteronomy — governance by an external authority, or by one's own unexamined inclinations — necessarily lacks.

This essay borrows the architecture of that picture and redirects it inward. Where Kant's Kingdom of Ends is a community of distinct persons, personal imperialism reads it as a model for the relation among the various "parts" of a single person — desire, inclination,

understanding, practical reason — any of which might otherwise pull the self in a different direction. On this reading, what integrates a self is not the suppression of its plural drives by a single ruling faculty imposed from outside, but their incorporation into a structure in which each is, in some sense, both legislator and subject: no drive is simply crushed, but none is left to rule unchecked either. It should be said plainly that this is a creative extension of Kant's concept, not an interpretation Kant himself offers or would likely endorse; the Kingdom of Ends is explicitly intersubjective, a picture of how separate rational agents ought to relate to one another, and nothing in the Groundwork licenses reading it as a model of intrapsychic order.

The extension is defensible, if at all, only because Kant's broader ethical writing contains a genuine intrapsychic analogue. The *Metaphysics of Morals*, in its Doctrine of Virtue, treats moral strength as the human being's capacity to constrain his own inclinations by his own reason — a form of self-constraint internal to a single agent, rather than distributed across a community of agents (Kant 1996). It is this narrower, already-Kantian notion of self-constraint, more than the properly intersubjective Kingdom of Ends, that does the real philosophical work being borrowed here. The essay retains the phrase "Kingdom of Ends" because it names the structural ideal — simultaneous legislation and subjection — more vividly than "self-constraint" does, at the cost of the interpretive liberty just flagged.

The first layer of personal imperialism, then, is legislative: the self does not simply discover a pre-given law it must obey, nor does it invent its commitments arbitrarily; it gives itself law in a manner answerable to reason, and remains bound by what it has given. This layer supplies form. It does not, by itself, supply content — and it is exactly here that Kant's picture needs supplementing.

2.2 Nietzsche: Will to Power and the Peril of the Text

If Kant supplies personal imperialism's legislative form, Nietzsche is meant to supply its evaluative content — the process by which the law's substance is continually made and remade rather than fixed once and for all. The relevant resources are the notion of self-overcoming (*Selbstüberwindung*), most vividly staged in *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, and the broader claim, developed across the published works of the 1880s, that values are created and reinterpreted from a particular perspective and situation rather than discovered in a mind-independent order (Nietzsche 1966; 1978). "Will to power," on this reading, names less a metaphysical substance than a diagnostic lens: to ask after the will to power in a value, a practice, or a morality is to ask what configuration of strength, growth, or self-overcoming it expresses or inhibits.

A rigorous use of this material has to reckon with a well-documented philological problem. The book many readers encounter as Nietzsche's systematic statement of the doctrine, *The Will to Power*, is not a book Nietzsche wrote. It is a selection from his notebooks, assembled and ordered after his 1889 collapse by his sister, Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche, together with Heinrich Köselitz ("Peter Gast"), and first published in 1901, with expanded editions in 1906 and 1911 (Nietzsche 1967). By the end of the summer of 1888, Nietzsche had himself abandoned the plan for a book under that title in favor of a differently organized project, "Attempt at a Revaluation of All Values"; the notes later marketed as *The Will to Power* include

material he did not select, in an order he did not choose, for a book that, on the best current scholarship, he had already set aside (Young 2010). The subsequent critical edition of Nietzsche's papers prepared by Giorgio Colli and Mazzino Montinari restored the notebook material to its original manuscript context and, in doing so, undercut the earlier compilation's claim to represent a finished, authorial book at all — a judgment those editors stated in unusually strong terms (Colli and Montinari 1980). Because Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche's own political sympathies later ran toward German nationalism, the compilation's history is also inseparable from the twentieth century's worst misappropriations of Nietzsche's name.

None of this makes the phrase "will to power" unusable; it recurs, if less systematically, throughout the works Nietzsche did publish and authorize. But it does mean that a paper drawing on the concept owes its reader a methodological statement, and this essay's is simple: personal imperialism's second, evaluative layer draws on will to power as a thematic motif recurring across Nietzsche's authorized corpus — self-overcoming, perspectival value-creation, suspicion of any morality that presents itself as simply given — rather than treating the posthumous compilation as a systematic doctrine to be applied wholesale.

Even set on this more cautious footing, the concept sits uneasily beside the Kantian layer it is meant to supplement. Nietzsche's mature work is deeply suspicious of exactly the kind of unified, continuous subject that a "kingdom" — inner or outer — seems to presuppose; his recurring argument that the grammatical subject "I" is closer to a fiction imposed on a plurality of drives than to a discovered unity cuts directly against any picture of the self as a single legislating sovereign (Nietzsche 1966). Equally, his treatment of universalizable moral law as one of the more sophisticated disguises available to what he calls slave morality sits badly next to a Kantian insistence that legislation must answer to universal reason. This essay does not propose to dissolve that tension. It proposes, in Section 3, to make the tension structural rather than to paper over it.

2.3 Jünger: The Gestalt of the Worker and Total Mobilization

The third source is the most historically fraught. In a 1930 essay, "Total Mobilization," Ernst Jünger argued that modern industrial warfare had dissolved the older liberal distinction between front and home front, combatant and civilian: the entire fabric of a society — its labor, its industry, its symbolic life alike — could now be drawn as a unified whole into the apparatus of conflict, no longer parceled out between the battlefield and everything behind it (Jünger [1930] 1993). Two years later, in *Der Arbeiter*, translated into English as *The Worker: Dominion and Form*, he generalized this diagnosis into a portrait of a new anthropological figure, the Gestalt of the Worker, superseding the bourgeois individual — not as a class category in Marx's sense, but as a metaphysical one: a mode of existence fused with technology, organized around neither the liberal opposition of freedom and constraint nor that of individual and collective (Jünger [1932] 2017).

Personal imperialism's third layer takes from this the idea of totality of engagement — a self whose capacities are not partially deployed, held in reserve, or compartmentalized, but mobilized as a whole into whatever form its legislated and revalued commitments actually take.

Where the Kantian layer supplies form and the Nietzschean layer supplies content, the Jüngerian layer supplies actuality: legislation and evaluation that never issue in total, embodied enactment remain merely notional.

This borrowing cannot responsibly proceed without situating *Der Arbeiter* historically. The book belongs to what historian Jeffrey Herf called "reactionary modernism": an intellectual tendency, prominent in Weimar Germany and exemplified above all by Jünger and Oswald Spengler, that fused genuine enthusiasm for industrial technology with a considered hostility to Enlightenment rationalism and to liberal-democratic government (Herf 1984). Jünger wrote *Der Arbeiter* on the eve of the Nazi seizure of power and never joined the NSDAP; commentators on the English translation note that his account of the Worker deliberately resists the biological race-theory then current in Nazi ideology, casting the concept instead in explicitly metaphysical terms (Jünger [1932] 2017). That distinction is real, but it is not a discharge. Total mobilization, in its original register, is a theory of how a modern state absorbs an entire society into war; borrowing its structure for an ethics of the self requires an explicit act of translation, and the essay is not entitled to assume that translation is costless. The point is taken up directly in Section 5.

3. The Tripartite Structure of Personal Imperialism

Bringing the three registers together yields a structure in three layers: legislative (Kantian), evaluative (Nietzschean), and mobilizational (Jüngerian). The temptation, in presenting a synthesis of this kind, is to describe the layers as smoothly nested — legislation setting the frame within which values are revalued, revaluation supplying content that mobilization then enacts — as though the three simply divided the labor of selfhood among themselves without friction. The account offered here resists that temptation, for a reason already implicit in Section 2: the three sources do not agree with one another, and a structure honest about its own materials should show the disagreement rather than hide it.

Consider what each layer looks like in isolation. Legislation without revaluation ossifies: a self that only ever acts on law it has already given itself, and never re-examines that law's content, becomes rigid — a rule-follower rather than a moral agent, close to the "dead letter" formalism Nietzsche accused Kantian ethics of producing. Revaluation without legislation dissolves: a self that continually remakes its values with no answerability to any standing commitment has no way to distinguish growth from mere caprice, and Nietzsche's own insistence on discipline and severity toward oneself, as a precondition of genuine self-overcoming, suggests he did not intend revaluation to mean formlessness. Mobilization without either becomes mere activity: motion without direction, the total engagement of one's capacities in the service of nothing in particular — a risk located by more than one of Jünger's critics in his prose itself, which some readers experience as a fascination with intensity for its own sake, detached from any account of what the intensity is for.

Personal imperialism, on the reading proposed here, names the condition of holding all three simultaneously — not as a resolved synthesis in which the tensions above disappear, but as something closer to a mixed constitution, in which each register checks the pathology native to

the other two. This is a substantive claim and should be stated with the appropriate qualification: nothing said so far demonstrates that three registers drawn from mutually critical philosophers can be held together in a single life without one of them simply winning. What the essay claims is more modest — that naming the tension explicitly, as a structure to be inhabited rather than a problem to be solved, is a more honest description of what integration under modern conditions actually demands than either a purely legislative ethics, which risks rigidity, or a purely expressivist one, which risks dissolution, can offer on its own.

4. Situating Personal Imperialism: Adjacent Discourses

The nearest existing body of work is Michel Foucault's account of technologies of the self: the practices, ancient and modern, by which individuals act upon their own bodies, thoughts, and conduct in order to transform themselves toward some state of happiness, purity, or wisdom (Foucault 1988). Foucault's late work returns repeatedly to Hellenistic and Roman ethics of self-care, care of the self, as an alternative to a purely juridical or confessional relation to oneself. There is a real affinity here: both projects treat selfhood as something practiced and made rather than simply found, and both resist the idea of a natural, pre-given self awaiting discovery. The difference is in ambition and method. Foucault's analysis is genealogical: it describes historically specific practices without proposing that any one of them, including the ancient ones he clearly admires, supplies a template binding on the present. Personal imperialism, by contrast, is architectonic — it proposes a structure, the tripartite one described in Section 3, as something closer to a standing requirement than a historically contingent practice among others. Whether that ambition is warranted, or whether it repeats a totalizing gesture Foucault's own historicism was designed to resist, is a fair question this essay does not claim to have settled.

A second, older precedent is the Stoic tradition, particularly Epictetus's insistence on the disciplined distinction between what is "up to us" and what is not (Epictetus 2008), and Marcus Aurelius's practice of the daily, written re-examination of his own judgments (Marcus Aurelius 2002). Both figures anticipate, in a more austere register, something like personal imperialism's combination of legislative discipline and continual re-application; what they lack, by comparison, is anything resembling the Nietzschean or Jüngerian emphasis on value-creation and totalizing mobilization. The Stoic sage governs appetite; he does not, in Nietzsche's sense, revalue it.

It is also worth distinguishing personal imperialism from a nearer and more suspect contemporary cousin: the discourse of the "sovereign individual" associated with libertarian and techno-utopian writing, in which self-sovereignty figures chiefly as freedom from collective institutions and as a precondition for wealth accumulation and exit from the constraints of the nation-state (Davidson and Rees-Mogg 1997). Personal imperialism, as developed here, has no necessary connection to that project and no interest in its economic or political program; its sovereignty is claimed only over the plurality internal to a single life, and it says nothing about how such a self ought to relate, politically or economically, to institutions or to other people. The resemblance is at the level of vocabulary only, and it is flagged here

precisely to avoid the essay being read as a philosophical gloss on a movement it does not endorse.

5. Objections and Limitations

Three objections deserve direct treatment.

The first, already flagged in the Introduction, concerns the vocabulary itself. To describe an ethical project in the language of empire — sovereignty, incorporation, dominion, mobilization — is to borrow words whose entire history concerns the domination of some people by others. Even granting that personal imperialism insists its sovereignty is claimed only reflexively, over one's own faculties, and never over other persons, a serious worry remains: metaphors are not inert containers that can be filled with whatever content one likes and safely bounded thereafter. A self habituated to describing its own inner life in terms of conquest and mobilization may find that vocabulary migrating outward, licensing a way of treating other people as material to be incorporated, mobilized, or brought under dominion for the sake of the self's own project. The essay's response is not to deny the risk but to make the reflexivity constraint explicit and non-negotiable: personal imperialism, on pain of no longer being the concept under discussion, applies only to a person's relation to their own drives, commitments, and capacities. Whether that constraint can actually hold once the vocabulary is in circulation is an empirical and rhetorical question this essay cannot settle by stipulation alone, and it is offered here as the single most important open problem for any future development of the concept.

The second objection is methodological. Kant, Nietzsche, and Jünger are not merely different; on several of the questions personal imperialism most needs answered — whether reason is universal or irreducibly perspectival, whether the self is a genuine unity or a fiction convenient for grammar, whether freedom consists in autonomy under self-given law or in a self-overcoming that answers to no antecedent law at all — they are direct antagonists, and each would likely raise serious objections to being enlisted alongside the other two. Section 3's proposal, that the tension be treated as structural rather than resolved, is one response to this difficulty, but it should be recognized for what it is: a way of living with an eclecticism the essay has not demonstrated is philosophically stable, rather than a proof that the three can be genuinely synthesized. Readers who find eclecticism of this kind unacceptable in principle will not be satisfied by Section 3, and the essay does not have a further argument in reserve against that position.

The third objection concerns the essay's level of abstraction. Nothing said so far describes what a life organized by personal imperialism would actually look like from the inside — what practices, if any, correspond to legislation, revaluation, and mobilization in an ordinary week, and how a person would recognize the difference between exercising this kind of self-governance and merely rationalizing whatever they were already doing. This is a genuine limitation rather than a rhetorical concession: the essay is programmatic, and a phenomenological or first-person elaboration, perhaps in dialogue with contemplative or practical traditions that already possess a rich vocabulary for exactly this kind of description, is necessary future work that this essay does not undertake.

6. Conclusion

This essay has proposed personal imperialism as a name for a specific, reflexive project: the integration of a life's competing drives, evaluative commitments, and capacities under a structure borrowed, with substantial modification, from Kant's Kingdom of Ends, Nietzsche's will to power, and Jünger's *Gestalt of the Worker*. Its central claim is not that these three sources can be smoothly synthesized — on the terms in which their original authors intended them, they cannot — but that the tension among them, treated as structural rather than as a defect to be resolved, offers a more honest account of what integration under contemporary conditions of fragmentation actually requires than any one of the three could supply alone. The essay has tried to be equally honest about what remains unresolved: the risk that its central metaphor imports more of empire's violence than its reflexive framing can contain, the eclecticism inherent in yoking together three mutually critical philosophers, and the absence, so far, of any concrete account of what the framework would mean for a life actually lived. Personal imperialism is offered here as a provocation and a starting point for further work, philosophical and phenomenological alike, rather than as a completed position.

Declaration on the Use of Artificial Intelligence

This revised version of the essay was prepared with the assistance of Claude, a large language model developed by Anthropic (Claude Sonnet model family; used in August 2026). The author's original draft set out the core proposal — personal imperialism as a tripartite structure combining Kantian legislation, Nietzschean revaluation, and Jüngerian mobilization — in a considerably shorter and more schematic form. The AI system was used to: expand the exposition of each philosophical source with additional textual and historical detail; identify and verify the bibliographic citations listed in the References section against publicly available sources; draft the discussion of adjacent discourses in Section 4 and the objections in Section 5; and restructure and copyedit the whole into its present form, including the Abstract. The author reviewed the resulting text, made editorial revisions, and takes full responsibility for all interpretive claims, citations, and any remaining errors. No data, quotations, or sources were fabricated by the AI system in the course of this revision. Readers with questions about the division of labor between author and AI system on any specific passage are welcome to contact the author directly.

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